

HIT YOUR JAZZ GOALS!

DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #81

I get asked all the time about what to practice, what NOT to practice, how to get better quicker, and how to divide up our practice time. I also hear from many people who are playing at about the same level as they were playing last year, and assuming that is the way it has to be. It's not.

For most adult amateur and semi-pro players, the people I like to talk to, you should be playing NOTICEABLY BETTER every four or six months. If your understanding and performance isn't moving ahead that quickly, there are some things not in place with your practice, or some elements missing. Let's fix it.

There are FOUR elements that should be in place pretty much every time you practice. If two or three practice sessions go by and you haven't addressed all four of these elements, you are letting air out of the balloon.

1) Be an ACTIVE part of a community

This is the most important part, and historically the hardest to find for many of us. Jazz is a team sport, and it is a long and tricky path to get to where you are going. You will need support, guidance, input and honest criticism of your playing. You need to *hear* from others, but you also need to offer ideas to others as well - a two way conversation. If you don't have this, you are in an echo chamber, listening only to yourself. You need to interact, not just listen. Be active.

University/College

Community based bands

www.JazzWire.net

2) Practice Your Instrument

Jazz is hard and tricky. You can quote me on that. The reality is that, totally aside from jazz music, you have to learn good technique on your instrument. The basics of how to play it with great timbre and great control. This could be tone development on a wind instrument, or hand control on the drums, or posture on the bass or the piano. You have to know how to operate the tool you've chosen if you want to be able to play all the hard stuff that jazz musicians love to play.

Technical Exercises/Etudes/Rudiments/Scales/Arpeggios, etc.

Tone Development

Posture and Position (be efficient, be in control, and don't hurt yourself)

Playing with Good Time

3) Practice and Learn Jazz Vocabulary

Improvisation is simply about making up your own melody, your own story, on the fly. Well, the more building blocks you have to work with, the better positioned you are to come up with something organized, historically accurate, and musically sensible. You need to be collecting ideas, devices and licks.

Jazz Licks from Great Players

Arpeggios, Stickings, Rudiments, Melodic Patterns and Devices

4) Practice and Learn Jazz Songs

Jazz musicians play . . . wait for it . . . jazz music. If you don't know any jazz songs, really know them, you are not going to progress. Your fingers will wiggle quickly (#2), you'll have a reason to practice again tomorrow (#1), and you'll even have some things to say (#3). But, you won't know where to put any of it. You'll sound great warming up, but won't be able to play a chorus of the blues that hangs together.

Learn Melodies (learn them technically correct, like an etude)

Memorize those Melodies, Memorize the Chord Changes

SING the Melodies (poorly w/ no words is fine), Sing the Roots of the Chords.

After 35+ years of teaching, 20 years of that focusing on adult amateurs and semi-pros, pretty much everything you need is included here. Is there anything missing from these four points? TONS IS MISSING. But here is the thing . . . everything missing follows from these four points. Ear Training? You get that from #2, #3, and especially #4. Working on your feel and sense of swing? Your team (#1) has plenty of input for you, and playing your instrument better (#2) will give you the tools to get there. Advanced Jazz Theory? The songs you are playing (#4) will lead you right to what you need to know, when you need to know it. How will you learn it? That is what your community (#1) is there for.

If you are not playing NOTICEABLY BETTER every four or six months, some elements are missing. Visit us at www.JazzWire.net for a plan to get you moving!

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